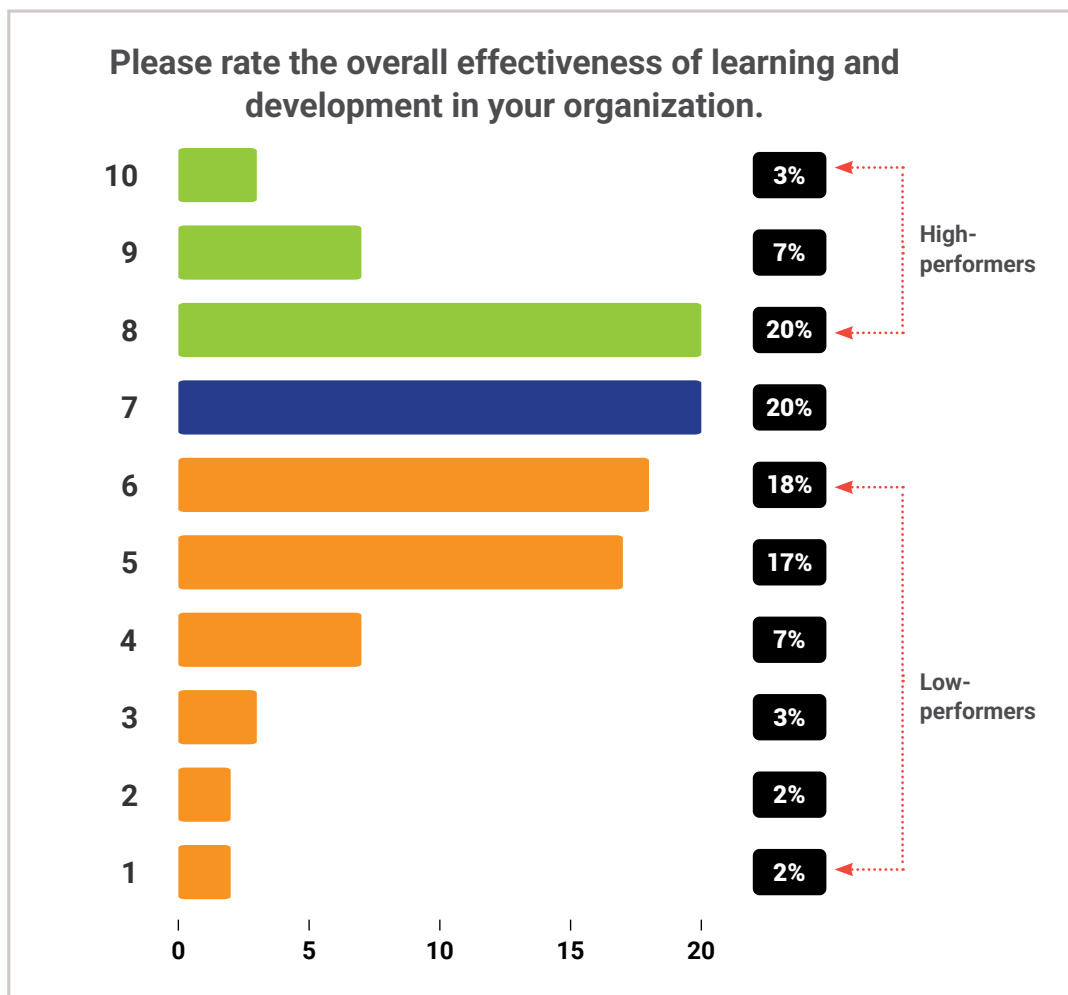


Strategic Priorities, Executive Alignment, and Skill Gaps



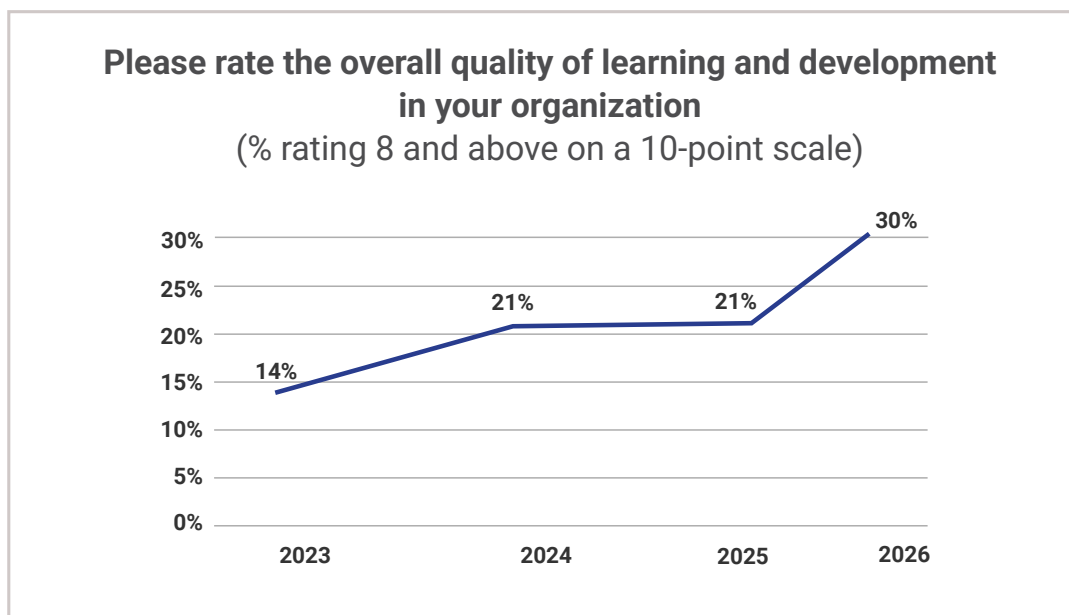
Finding: Only 30% rate their organization's L&D efforts as highly effective

When asked to what degree their organization's L&D efforts produce meaningful results such as improving performance or closing skill gaps, only 30% of respondents rate the overall effectiveness of their efforts at 8 or higher on a 10-point scale, while 55% assign ratings between 5 and 7. This suggests that although many organizations believe their learning programs are producing acceptable results, relatively few view them as a strong driver of organizational performance.



Note: Effectiveness refers to the degree to which your organization's L&D efforts produce meaningful results (e.g., improving performance, closing skill gaps).

Although the 2026 survey measures effectiveness rather than quality, the results continue a pattern observed over the past several years. In 2023, just 14% rated the quality of their L&D efforts highly, increasing to 21% in both 2024 and 2025. In 2026, 30% rate their L&D efforts as highly effective, suggesting some improvement over time. Across all four years, most respondents have consistently placed their organizations in the middle of the performance scale rather than at the high end.



Note: The questions remained identical across the 2023, 2024, and 2025 surveys. In 2025, the phrase “top-notch culture of learning in my organization” was slightly shortened to “culture of learning in my organization.” The 2026 survey measures “effectiveness” rather than “quality.”

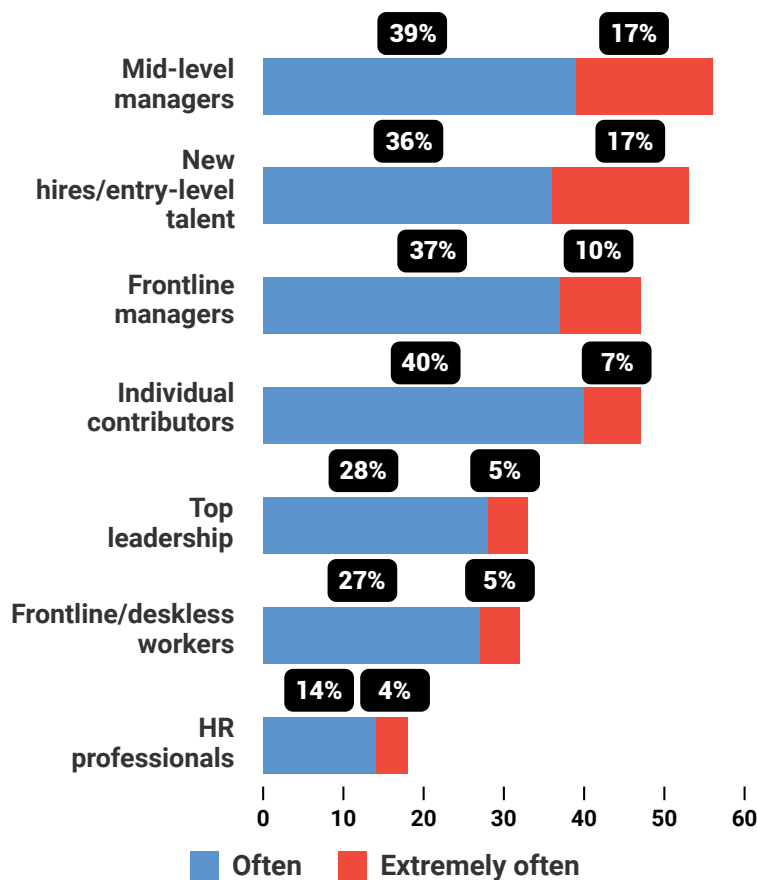


Finding: Almost three-fifths report that skills gaps occur often or extremely often among mid-level managers

Mid-level managers are the employee group most likely to experience skills gaps, with 56% of respondents reporting that these gaps occur often or extremely often.

[Global data](#) shows that up to 60% of frontline and mid-level managers receive no formal leadership training after promotion. At the same time, [Gartner's latest workforce research shows](#) that automation has slowed entry-level hiring, increasing organizational reliance on mid-level talent while weakening traditional leadership pipelines. As a result, many managers are stepping into strategic roles without adequate preparation.

In your organization, how often do you see skills gaps among the following employee groups:



When asked where organizations most need to focus their reskilling efforts to drive future success, experts heavily emphasized automation and real-time operational agility. David Creelman, CEO of Creelman Research, notes that automation is a critical priority, while Matthew Casey-Sudvary, PhD, specifies that organizations must prioritize *"Identifying redundant tasks that can be automated."*

JD Dillon, Advisor, Speaker, and Author, highlights a shift in necessary core competencies.

"As work becomes increasingly tech-driven and organizations continue to push for short-term gains, employees must develop their ability to foster relationships, build trust, adapt to ongoing change, and develop new capabilities to execute evolving systems and processes. Change management is out, adaptation and readiness are in." - JD Dillon

Becky Willis, Chief Learning Officer at Tractus, points to specific target roles across the enterprise that require immediate focus, stating that organizations must prioritize upskilling efforts for managers, IT, L&D/TD, data architects, and most office workers.



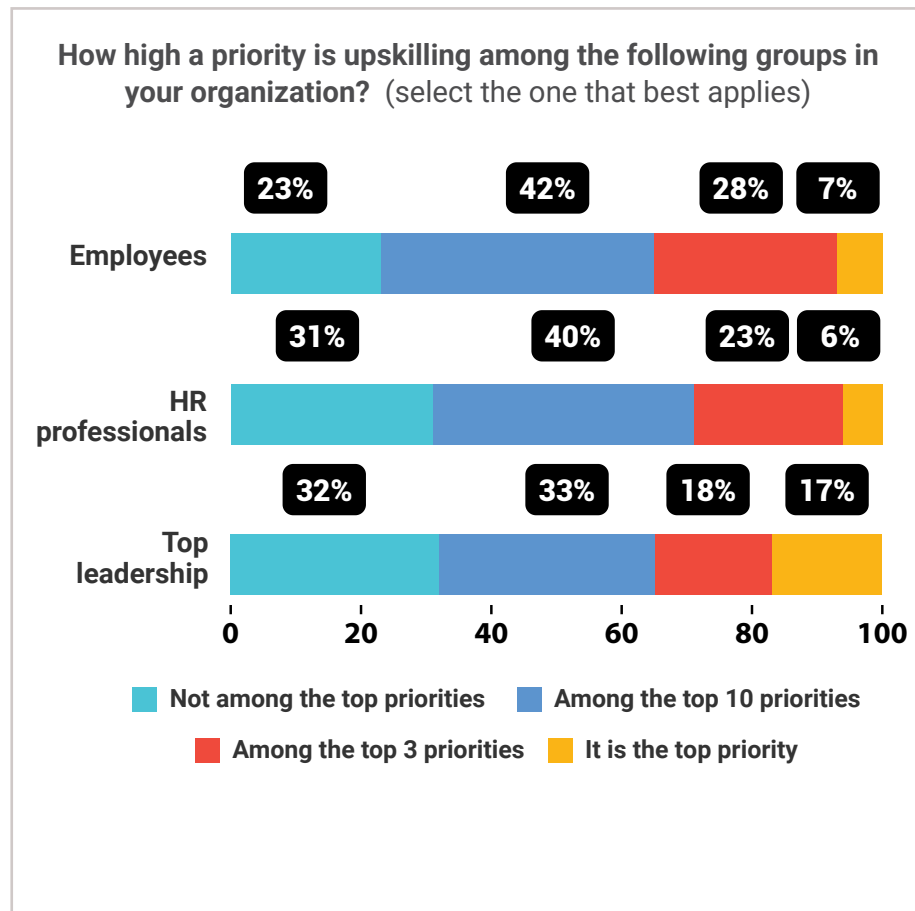
Finding: A third of respondents say that upskilling is not a priority for top leadership

Perceptions of the importance of upskilling vary across stakeholder groups. Employees place the greatest urgency on development, with 35% ranking upskilling as their top priority or among their top three priorities. Executives report a similar level of urgency, with 35% also placing upskilling within their top three priorities, although 32% do not consider it a priority at all.

One possible explanation is that many leaders remain focused on immediate operational and financial priorities, making investments in workforce development more difficult to justify despite growing evidence that skill shortages and technological change are increasing the need for continuous learning. HR professionals appear somewhat less likely to view upskilling as a top-tier issue, with fewer ranking it among their highest priorities.

These findings suggest that while a segment of leaders recognize the strategic importance of upskilling, employees may feel a stronger need for development opportunities and clearer pathways for skill growth. [Mercer's comprehensive evaluation](#) outlines a structural “triple misalignment” among employees, HR, and the C-suite. Their data confirms that most employees are deeply concerned about lacking future-ready skills, to the extent that 63% of workers would willingly trade a 10% pay raise for guaranteed upskilling opportunities.

Organizations that successfully position upskilling as a business priority rather than an employee benefit may be better equipped to secure executive support and sustained investment.



Editor's note: Respondents who answered "Don't know" were removed from the data set. They accounted for 1% to 10% of responses.



Finding: Thirty percent describe their L&D efforts as mostly aligned with broader talent management strategies

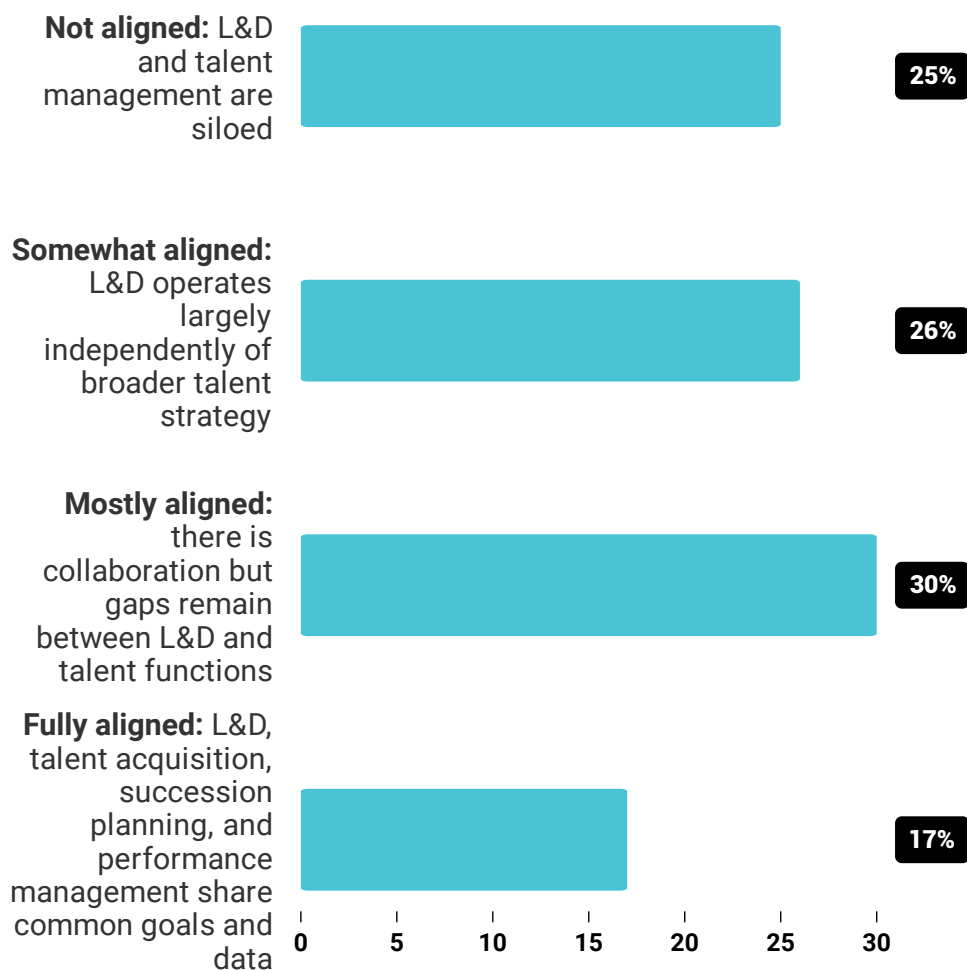
While 30% of respondents report that L&D efforts are mostly aligned with broader talent management strategies, relatively few organizations have achieved full alignment. Just 17% say that learning, talent acquisition, succession planning, and performance management share common goals and data.

At the same time, 26% report that L&D operates largely independently of broader talent strategy, and 25% say the two functions are not aligned at all. Together, this means that more than half of organizations report only limited alignment or outright separation between learning and talent management.

This lack of integration can limit an organization's ability to identify, develop, and deploy talent effectively. When learning, recruitment, performance management, and career development operate separately, organizations may struggle to connect skill development with workforce planning and internal mobility goals. To address this strategic misalignment, [McKinsey & Company](#) recommends aligning business, HR, and technology leaders around critical skills rather than managing learning in functional silos.

How well aligned are your organization's learning and development efforts with its broader talent management strategy?

(select the one that best applies)

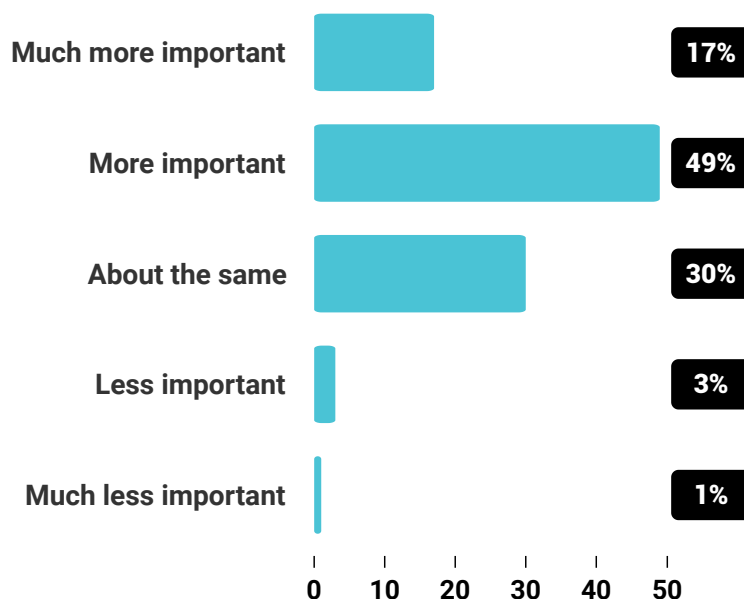




Finding: Two-thirds of respondents expect employee upskilling to become more important over the next two years

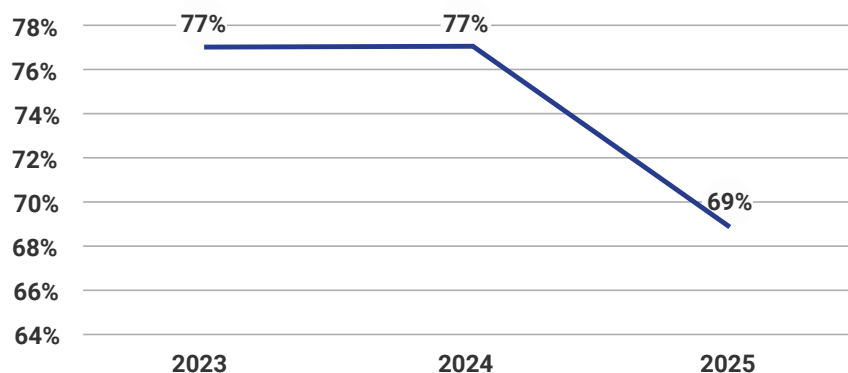
Upskilling has become an established workforce priority rather than a temporary response to disruption. Two-thirds of respondents (66%) expect upskilling to become either more important or much more important over the next two years, while only 4% expect it to become less or much less important. [Coursera's](#) research shows that organizations have stopped treating Generative AI-driven upskilling as a crisis to manage and started treating it as the new normal. As the report puts it, "acceleration is now the baseline."

Will employee upskilling in your organization become more or less important over the next two years? (select the one that best applies)



Longitudinal analysis reveals a consistent pattern. Since 2023, the percentage of respondents who expect upskilling to become more important or much more important has decreased slightly, but remains high, ranging from 69% to 77%. The modest decline may track the steady rise in perceived L&D effectiveness over the same period, as organizations that feel better equipped to deliver on upskilling may feel less pressure to flag its importance as sharply.

Will employee upskilling in your organization become more or less important over the next two years?
(% responding more or much more important)





Pulse Poll Finding: Leadership support is viewed as the single most important factor separating organizations that successfully leverage learning technologies from those that struggle to realize value

A companion HR Research Institute poll of 141 HR professionals found active leadership support (57%) to be the strongest differentiator between organizations that realize value from learning technology and those that don't, ahead of content quality (44%) and dedicated learning time (43%), reinforcing this report's core finding that leadership engagement drives results.

Organizations are more likely to realize value from learning technologies when leaders actively champion learning initiatives, align learning with business priorities, and create the conditions that enable employees to develop new skills.

What three factors distinguish organizations that successfully leverage learning technologies from those that struggle to realize value? (select up to three)



Note: These findings are from the HR Research Institute Question of the Day poll.

HRRI Strategic Recommendations

Based on our research, please consider the following suggestions:

1. Connect learning initiatives to business priorities

Learning programs are more likely to gain leadership support when they address specific business challenges. Rather than building programs around available content, focus development efforts on the skills and capabilities that will have the greatest impact on organizational success. Consider:

- identifying the top workforce challenges facing the organization
- prioritizing development efforts that address critical skill gaps
- aligning learning objectives with business goals
- regularly communicating the business value of learning initiatives

2. Make manager development a top priority

Managers have a significant influence on employee performance, engagement, and growth. Investing in manager capability can improve team effectiveness while strengthening the overall learning culture. Consider:

- providing leadership development for new and experienced managers
- strengthening coaching and feedback skills
- helping managers identify and address skill gaps within their teams
- equipping managers to support employee development conversations

3. Align learning with talent management processes

Learning should not operate independently from hiring, performance management, succession planning, and career development. Connecting these processes helps ensure development efforts support broader talent goals. Consider:

- partnering with talent acquisition and talent management teams
- aligning learning pathways with career progression opportunities
- incorporating skill development into performance discussions
- using workforce planning data to inform learning priorities

4. Measure whether learning is making a difference

Tracking course completions and participation rates is important, but it does not show whether learning is improving workforce capability. Focus on measures that demonstrate impact. Consider:

- assessing whether critical skill gaps are decreasing
- tracking internal promotions and mobility
- evaluating manager and leadership readiness
- gathering feedback on how learning is being applied on the job